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Culture (OWC): [Ovambo \(FX08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1924-1976

Coverage Date: 1915 AD - 1965 AD

Place Coverage

north-central Namibia; Cunene Province, Angola

Section Title(S): 2. Proverbs And Riddles

2. Proverbs and Riddles

I have called the literary phenomena expressed in these two forms, proverbs and riddles, a "genre intermediate between prose and poetry." It will not be necessary to go into a long explanation to justify my classification. Once we know the essence of the Bantu law of poetry, it will be easy to recognize poetic character in many proverbs and riddles, which I shall transcribe, translate, and explain. The fundamental law of Bantu poetic art resides in parallelism, just as it does in Semitic poetry. Both races, when they wish to employ an exalted, emphatic language, resort to repeating an idea in parallel phrases, using different forms of expression. This often involves the use of synonyms in complementary "verses." Sometimes—rarely—antithesis replaces synonymy. To heighten the poetic effect still further, numerous metaphors are used. Let me give a very simple example. The Kwanyama herdsman will sing of a white cow (white but streaked or spotted with another color) in these words:



*Ositokela sa Kalunga,
Osihanangolo sa Pamba.*

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Ositokela, instead of *ositoka*, means simply "white." *Osihanangolo*, as we have seen, denotes a girl in the second phase of the puberty celebration, who is powdered with ashes. To employ this term for a cow is obviously metaphorical. *Kalunga* is a noun which denotes the Supreme Being. The term *Pamba* is strictly synonymous with *Kalunga* and is used almost exclusively in poetry, precisely for the sake of parallelism.

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As everywhere else, proverbs (*omise*) are the salt of discourse. But, as is the rule for that condiment, they must not be overused. Not only excessive but also inappropriate uses are often felt by the sensitive Kwanyama to be a joke made at his expense. It is significant that individuals who know some Portuguese but do not know the term *provérbio* "proverb")  163 consider the native word well translated by the word *piada* ("joke").

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